"Before arising, there is absence. Before absence, there is arising.
Before both, there Is Being."

Being and Non-Being: Beyond Extremes

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Reflection…
We constantly observe the emergence of the "existence" of phenomena, a certain duration of their being, and their disappearance or "non-existence."
Let us consider the concept of the "existence" of phenomena from both relative and absolute perspectives, distinguishing between the corresponding categories:

Relative "existence"
It does not create, in an absolute sense, **a phenomenon that did not exist before**. The **emergence of a phenomenon's "existence" is relative**. For example, a craftsman creates a clay vase, leading to the "existence" of a new phenomenon. If we draw an analogy, **the existence of the clay vase** as a phenomenon **is relative**, whereas the **"existence" of the clay itself** is **absolute** (clay does not exist in an absolute sense; it is a substance composed of constituent parts. The example is merely intended to aid understanding).

Absolute "existence"
This **is the emergence of a phenomenon's "existence"** that has **never existed before**. It represents the creation of an entirely new entity. An example would be the concept of God as the Creator, who sequentially brings into existence all phenomena (light, space, matter, humans, etc.).

The very **concept of the emergence of "existence" is dependent**, as only that which previously "did not exist" can "emerge." Otherwise, speaking **of the emergence of the "existence" of phenomena becomes meaningless**. As seen above, the emergence of the "existence" of phenomena is possible only on the condition that there was a prior "non-existence" of phenomena—whether **relative** or **absolute**.

If we accept the eternalist claim that **all phenomena absolutely "exist,"** then these phenomena would be self-sufficient, unchanging, and independent. In such a scenario, it would be impossible to explain the processes of emergence, duration, disappearance, and interaction of phenomena on a relative level. For example, anger would have always existed, and consciousness would be incapable of perceiving sensory objects because it would be something entirely independent and immutable. **Therefore, eternalism is ruled out**.

In the second part of the statement, **I use the concept of "absence"** as a synonym for "non-being" or "non-existence." Here, we can also distinguish two categories:

Relative "non-existence"
This does not imply the absolute "non-existence" of phenomena. For instance, apples do not appear on an apple tree because they "do not exist yet" (e.g., in spring), or they "no longer exist" (e.g., in winter). However, we do not assert that apples are "non-existent" in an absolute sense when they are absent.

Absolute "non-existence"

If phenomena have never arisen in the past, do not exist in the present, and will never arise in the future, they **absolutely "do not exist"** and are thus unchangeable and independent. For example, the "son of a barren woman" does not "exist" (past-present-future) and cannot exist anywhere—neither in reality nor in illusion.

One who claims (while being a phenomenon themselves and observing the diversity of phenomena) that phenomena **absolutely "do not exist"** falls into the extreme of nihilism. If we accept the nihilist assertion of the absolute "non-existence" of phenomena as true, it would then be impossible to justify the **relative "existence"** of phenomena, and causality would become invalid. Therefore, nihilism is also ruled out.

Thus, by **freeing ourselves from the two extremes** of the "being" of phenomena—absolute "existence" and absolute "non-existence"—we remove the veil of ignorance and realize **Suchness (tathatā)**— **The True Nature of Reality.**

Namaste